

THE SELF-EMPLOYED PERSON'S GUIDE TO

Health Insurance in Tennessee

What nobody tells you

A plain-English walkthrough of your real coverage options, the numbers that actually matter, and how to choose a plan that protects you when it counts.

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INTRODUCTION

A Note From Denton

If you work for yourself, finding health insurance can feel like navigating a system that was not built for you. That is because it was not. The traditional market was designed around employer-sponsored coverage, so if you are self-employed, a 1099 contractor, a freelancer, or a small business owner, your options look very different from what your employed friends have.

A quick word on me. I was born and raised in Nolensville and grew up here in the Middle Tennessee area, and I studied at the University of Tennessee and Middle Tennessee State University. Today I live in Smyrna and work with self-employed Tennesseans across the state. I am not a captive agent or a call center. I shop the whole market and tell you what I would do if I were in your seat.

This guide covers your real options, how to compare them, what to watch out for, and how to make a decision that protects you when it matters. No jargon. No sales pitch.

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OUR CLIENTS

Who We Help Most

Independent Contractors & 1099 Workers

Trades, consultants, and IT pros with 1099 income and no employer plan.

Freelancers & Consultants

Designers, marketers, copywriters, and coaches running their own business.

Salon Owners & Beauty Pros

Booth renters, stylists, and nail techs handling their own benefits.

Travel Nurses & Healthcare Contractors

Per diem and travel workers needing portable, multi-state coverage.

Gig Economy Workers

Platform workers classified as contractors with no employer benefits.

Realtors & Real Estate Agents

Commission income and no benefits, so coverage works around a variable paycheck.

Owner-Operators & Truck Drivers

You own the rig and the business, so nationwide PPO networks matter.

Contractors & Skilled Trades

Electricians, plumbers, HVAC techs, and roofers running their own crews.

Small Business Owners

Individual coverage for you, with options for employees, minus group complexity.

Therapists & Private Practice

Counselors, chiropractors, and practitioners managing their own benefits.

Your Three Real Options

Most self-employed Tennesseans do not realize they have three distinct lanes. Knowing the difference is the first step to the right choice.

LANE 1

ACA Marketplace Plans

Plans at [healthcare.gov](https://www.healthcare.gov) are available to any Tennessee resident who meets basic eligibility. They are guaranteed issue, so you cannot be turned down for your health history.

Best for: lower to moderate income individuals who qualify for premium tax credit subsidies.

Watch out for: narrow regional networks, high deductibles on lower tiers, and income cliffs that can wipe out subsidies.

LANE 2

Medically Underwritten Private PPO Plans

Bought outside the marketplace, directly from a carrier. These go through medical underwriting, so your health history affects eligibility and premium. In exchange you typically get broader nationwide networks, lower deductibles, and more flexibility.

Best for: individuals in good health who earn above the subsidy threshold or want nationwide network access.

Watch out for: pre-existing conditions may affect eligibility or premium. Not available to everyone.

LANE 3

Supplemental & Gap Coverage

Accident, critical illness, hospital indemnity, dental, and vision plans layer on top of a primary plan to fill gaps and reduce out-of-pocket exposure.

Best for: anyone who wants to reduce financial risk beyond what their primary plan covers.

Watch out for: these are not a replacement for primary coverage. They work alongside it.

The 4 Numbers That Actually Matter

Most people shop on one number: the monthly premium. That is a mistake. These four decide how a plan performs when you actually use it.

- 1 Monthly Premium**
What you pay every month whether or not you use your insurance. Lower premiums usually mean higher costs when you need care.
- 2 Deductible**
What you pay out of pocket before insurance starts sharing costs. A \$6,000 deductible means you cover the first \$6,000 of expenses yourself each year.
- 3 Coinsurance**
After the deductible, you and your insurer split costs. At 80/20, insurance pays 80% and you pay 20%, until you reach your out-of-pocket maximum.
- 4 Out-of-Pocket Maximum**
The ceiling on what you pay in a year. Once you hit it, insurance covers 100% of covered costs for the rest of the year. This is the most important number for protecting against a serious health event.

Key insight: A plan with a \$300 premium and an \$8,700 out-of-pocket max could cost you \$12,300 in a bad year. A plan with a \$500 premium and a \$3,000 max costs \$9,000 at most. The cheaper plan is not always cheaper.

WHAT TO AVOID

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- 1 Choosing a plan on premium alone**
The cheapest premium often carries the highest deductible and out-of-pocket costs. Model a moderate and a worst-case year before you decide.
- 2 Assuming the ACA marketplace is your only option**
Many in good health qualify for private PPO plans with better networks and lower deductibles, often at a similar or lower total cost.
- 3 Skipping supplemental coverage**
A serious accident, a cancer diagnosis, or a hospital stay can run far beyond your primary plan. Supplemental plans pay cash benefits directly to you.
- 4 Not reviewing coverage every year**
Your income, health, and needs change. A plan that fit two years ago may not fit today, and an annual review costs nothing.
- 5 Going it alone**
An independent agent who shops the whole market explains what you are actually buying. It costs you nothing, since the carrier pays the broker, not you.

Is a Private PPO Right for You?

A private PPO is not right for everyone, but for many self-employed Tennesseans it is the strongest option available. Here is how to tell if it fits.

You may be a good candidate if you:

- ✓ Are in generally good health with no major pre-existing conditions
- ✓ Earn too much to qualify for meaningful ACA subsidies
- ✓ Want a broader nationwide network of doctors and specialists
- ✓ Prefer lower deductibles and more predictable out-of-pocket costs
- ✓ Value seeing any doctor or specialist without a referral
- ✓ Travel for work and need coverage that follows you across state lines

An ACA plan may serve you better if you:

- ✗ Have significant pre-existing conditions that affect underwriting
- ✗ Qualify for substantial ACA premium tax credits based on income
- ✗ Are between jobs and need temporary short-term coverage

Bottom line: the only way to know which option wins for your situation is to compare both side by side with real numbers. That is exactly what a free consultation provides.

NEXT STEPS

What a Consultation Looks Like

A free 15-minute call is not a sales call. Here is what actually happens.

- 1 We start with your situation**
Your income, your health, your current coverage if any, and what matters most to you in a plan.
- 2 We pull quotes across every lane**
ACA marketplace, private PPO, and supplemental coverage, with real numbers for your situation.
- 3 We walk through the comparison**
Deductibles, networks, and out-of-pocket maximums, and what each plan costs in a normal year versus a bad one.
- 4 You decide**
No pressure and no timeline. If what you have is your best option, I will tell you. Most people leave with more clarity than they came in with.

BOOK YOUR FREE REVIEW

Ready to see your real options?

Book a free 15-minute consultation. No sales pitch. No pressure. Just clarity on your actual options, with real numbers for your situation.

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